Rani Durgavati's reputation for valour rests on the war that followed. In brief, the story is that the rani, mounted on her best elephant, a 'lofty and swift' animal called Sarman, fought bravely until, on the cusp of defeat, her neck bleeding from an arrow wound, the queen of the Gonds drew out her own dagger and took her own life.[23]

A more elaborate account reveals that Rani Durgavati was let down by her own side as much as she was defeated by Asaf Khan's. It was the rani, first of all, who gave her 5000-odd troops the appetite for a fight, declaring they might leave if they liked but she would not, for how long was she to hide 'among trees'? She would 'fall or she would conquer'. Then, putting 'armour on her breast and a helmet on her head', she led her men – including her now-adult son Bir Sah – at the far larger Mughal army (10,000 cavalry alone) and made a successful onslaught. Three hundred of Asaf Khan's men were killed, writes Abul Fazl; the 'Rani was victorious'.

That evening, however, the queen's luck turned. She held a council and proposed a surprise attack that very night, to deny Asaf Khan any opportunity to fortify his position. 'No one agreed,' writes Abul Fazl. She proposed the idea again, this time to a smaller council of her most loyal men. They, too, let the moment pass.

The next morning, Asaf Khan was, indeed, better positioned. Still, the rani's men fought their best. It was a bloody, exhausting struggle; for three watches of the day, the battle raged, men falling one upon the other. At one point, writes a contemporary historian called Shaikh Illahdad, soldiers on both sides threw away their 'guns and arrows . . . seized each other's collars, and fought hand to hand'.[24] Bir Sah, the young king in whose stead his mother had ruled these past sixteen years, broke through enemy ranks thrice until he was wounded. The rani ordered her son taken away.

She had let maternal instinct get the better of martial reasoning. It may have been the rani who led the men upon her elephant, but when Bir Sah left, most of her army followed him.

Left with barely 300 men, Rani Durgavati 'continued to wage hot war' until she was struck by two arrows, one in the temple, the other in the neck. She fainted.

When the queen came to, her elephant was being driven to safety by a loyal chieftain called Adhar – the last man Rani Durgavati would ever lay